

What Counts as Abundance?

Abundance is an abstract term. It implies plenty, more than is needed, and even wealth. In the context of food, however, we often refer to food beyond that which is needed by a more technical term: **surplus**. Surplus food produced by farmers is more than is needed to keep their households fed over the coming year. That surplus may or may not be storable for a future lean year and, depending on the nature of the foodstuff that is the surplus, may or may not hold value within a society. The storage of food, or the conversion of raw food items into more storable forms, creates the possibility of building wealth that accumulates from year to year. For this reason, archaeologists are keen to identify agricultural surplus in the past, with a particular interest in how that surplus was stored, shared, traded, or consumed, and how social systems arose out of dealing with the problem of abundance!

Agricultural **surplus** is a term used by archaeologists to refer to produced food that is more than is needed by the producers (and their households) for ordinary (annual, in seasonal climates) subsistence.